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Artificial Intelligence in Qualitative Research: Insights From Experts via Reflexive Thematic Analysis

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Abstract

The rapid advancement of artificial intelligence (AI) is increasingly shaping research methodologies across disciplines. However, its integration in qualitative research remains controversial due to epistemological, ethical, and human-centered concerns. This study explores the perspectives of 14 expert qualitative researchers from socio-anthropological and healthcare fields working in Italian academic and hospital settings, with a focus on the opportunities, challenges, and future directions of AI use in qualitative inquiry. Through semi-structured interviews and reflexive thematic analysis, four main themes were developed. First, participants expressed ambivalent attitudes—balancing curiosity with technophobia and emphasizing the need for human oversight and contextual interpretation. Second, an anthropological and philosophical dimension was constructed, underscoring the importance of reflexivity, creativity, and researcher identity as essential counterbalances to AI's mechanistic tendencies. Third, researchers acknowledged AI's practical benefits in tasks such as transcription and data management, and they remained skeptical of its ability to perform complex interpretative work. Finally, ethical and sustainability concerns were raised, including algorithmic bias, data privacy, and the environmental impact of AI technologies. The findings reveal persistent epistemological tensions but also highlight emerging opportunities for AI to enhance research efficiency and accessibility, provided that human interpretative agency remains central. Participants stressed the importance of developing robust ethical frameworks, fostering critical reflexivity, and adopting innovative conceptual approaches to responsibly integrate AI into qualitative research and education. This study offers valuable insights for scholars and practitioners navigating the evolving landscape of AI in qualitative inquiry, advocating a balanced approach that leverages AI's potential while safeguarding the human core of qualitative research.

Keywords

artificial intelligence, perceptions, qualitative research, reflexive thematic analysis

Background

In recent years, artificial intelligence (AI) has become a pivotal driver of innovation across diverse fields, including healthcare, education, and scientific research (Balalle & Pannilage, 2025; Daniel et al., 2025; Gridach et al., 2025). As an interdisciplinary domain drawing on computer science, engineering, mathematics, linguistics, and psychology (Dwivedi et al., 2023), AI is typically divided into two main categories: predictive and generative. Predictive AI employs machine learning algorithms and statistical models to identify patterns and make decisions (Yehia, 2025). In contrast, generative AI produces novel content—such as text, images, audio, and video—using large foundational models trained through self-supervised learning (Leslie & Rossi, 2023; Sinha et al., 2024).

Generative AI has seen rapid uptake across sectors, including cybersecurity, energy, transportation, and education—and it is gaining prominence in healthcare. Its applications range from streamlining administrative processes to enhancing diagnostics and drug discovery (Ahuja

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et al., 2024). However, this growing integration is accompanied by concerns over algorithmic bias, lack of transparency, and regulatory complexity (Glicksberg & Klang, 2024). In academic settings, generative tools like ChatGPT are increasingly used in teaching and research, prompting mixed reactions: while they offer new opportunities to support research and improve efficiency, they also raise ethical questions and concerns over dependency and academic integrity (Christou, 2023; Turobov et al., 2024). In addition to analytical applications, AI tools are increasingly used to support academic writing, aiding clarity and inclusivity, although ethical considerations remain (Chanpradit, 2025; Christou, 2024).

In the realm of qualitative research, AI has recently been explored as a supportive tool for conceptualization, thematic analysis, and content analysis. While these applications may offer opportunities to accelerate analytical processes and extend interpretative capacity, they also raise critical questions regarding the reliability of findings, reproducibility of analyses, and ethical integrity of the research process (Christou, 2024). As these tools evolve and become more refined, their use in qualitative research is likely to increase. Researchers are increasingly experimenting with AI in tasks such as conducting literature reviews. Advanced AI solutions have demonstrated the potential to support semi-automated review processes (Bolaños et al., 2024; Liu et al., 2025). Although limitations remain, there is growing consensus that advanced AI will soon reshape the methodologies used for scientific reviews (Scherbakov et al., 2025).

In qualitative data analysis, AI plays a pivotal role in identifying recurring patterns, suggesting preliminary codes, and facilitating data organization (Luongo et al., 2025; Perkins & Roe, 2024; Roberts et al., 2024). Nonetheless, fundamental concerns persist around algorithmic transparency, epistemological validity, and the impact of automation on research authorship. Recent experimental studies comparing AI- and human-driven analyses in inductive and thematic research show that while AI excels in simple data processing and theme generation (Naeem et al., 2025), human researchers contribute nuanced understanding and interpretive depth (Perkins & Roe, 2024). These findings suggest a complementary relationship between generative AI and human researchers (Prescott et al., 2024), potentially evolving into a true intellectual partnership (Bunt et al., 2025). Regarding deductive approaches, research indicates that AI can reduce the time and cost associated with data processing, with moderate to high agreement levels compared to traditional methods. However, subtheme aggregation and final data interpretation still require human involvement to ensure contextual sensitivity and analytical depth (Pattyn, 2024). Scholars recommend collaborative models in which large language model outputs are reviewed, supplemented by inductive coding, and critically interpreted by human researchers (Balt et al., 2025).

Despite the increasing integration of AI in academic research, there remains a significant gap in the literature regarding qualitative researchers' subjective perceptions and critical reflections on its use. While experimental studies have compared AI- and human-generated outputs (Naeem et al., 2025; Perkins & Roe, 2024), and some surveys have examined the perceived utility and usability of AI tools (Chatzichristos, 2025), few have qualitatively investigated how researchers experience and interpret AI integration within their methodological practices. This lack of in-depth understanding limits the development of context-sensitive, ethically grounded, and methodologically robust guidelines for adopting AI in qualitative inquiry.

This study aims to explore the perspectives and lived experiences of qualitative researchers concerning the integration of AI into qualitative research. Focusing on scholars working in academic and healthcare research settings, it seeks to uncover how AI is perceived, adopted, or resisted in qualitative inquiry and to identify the epistemological, methodological, and ethical implications arising from its use.

Materials and Methods

Study Design

This study employed a qualitative interpretative design to deeply explore participants' experiences. Data were gathered via semi-structured interviews and analyzed using reflexive thematic analysis (RTA), following Braun and Clarke's approach (Braun & Clarke, 2021). To enhance transparency and methodological rigor, the analysis adhered to the Reflexive Thematic Analysis Reporting Guidelines (RTARGs) (Braun & Clarke, 2024), which provide a detailed framework for best practices and common pitfalls in RTA reporting (Morse, 2021).

RTA was chosen over other qualitative methods such as phenomenology, grounded theory, or content analysis because it facilitates the exploration of subjective meanings and researcher reflexivity without aiming to generate theory or focusing solely on lived experience. This flexibility suits studies seeking rich, interpretative accounts of patterns across complex educational and professional contexts, such as nursing students' development of health promotion competencies.

Despite its advantages, RTA's interpretative nature depends heavily on researcher subjectivity, potentially introducing bias. Furthermore, the lack of a fixed procedural blueprint can cause variability in application. These limitations were mitigated by strict adherence to RTARGs and ongoing reflexive practice throughout the analysis. This approach was well-aligned with the research question investigating the points of view and perceptions of a community of qualitative researchers regarding the use of AI in qualitative research, allowing identification of key themes that provide a nuanced and contextually relevant understanding.

Research Team

The research team comprises healthcare professionals, including two registered nurses with advanced academic qualifications and extensive expertise in qualitative research: one holding a Master of Science in Nursing and the other a Doctorate (PhD) (GA and FD). Both have received advanced training in qualitative methodologies. Additionally, the team includes two other nurses with master's degrees (AS and CC), who also possess strong competencies in qualitative research. This multidisciplinary team combines robust clinical experience with methodological rigor, ensuring a comprehensive and nuanced approach to the study.

Sampling

The study employed a purposive sampling strategy initially outlined by Campbell et al. (2020), targeting professionals from a range of disciplines, including sociology, nursing, medicine and surgery, and anthropology. These participants were affiliated with healthcare institutions and universities nationwide. All had advanced expertise in qualitative research, defined by the following criteria: having conducted at least two to three complete qualitative research projects, including design, data collection, analysis, and interpretation; having published at least one peer-reviewed article based on qualitative methodologies; possessing formal training in qualitative methods through advanced courses, workshops, or doctoral studies; holding active professional roles involving qualitative research responsibilities, such as supervising qualitative theses or leading research projects; and being recognized within their academic or professional communities as experts in qualitative research through invitations to present or participation in qualitative research networks. Participants voluntarily agreed to contribute their perspectives on the use of AI in qualitative research to the study.

Recruitment was carried out through convenience sampling. While some participants were professionally known to the researchers due to shared academic networks, not all interviewees had prior relationships with the research team. Selection was based on participants' demonstrated expertise in qualitative research and relevance to the study topic, rather than on pre-existing personal contacts.

Invitations to participate were sent via email to institutional addresses, providing detailed information about the study's objectives and methodology. Those expressing interest were given a Google® form to provide informed consent, including permission for video recording.

The sample size was guided by the depth and richness of engagement with the data rather than by the principle of saturation. Data collection continued until sufficient depth was achieved to meaningfully address the research questions, without aiming for thematic redundancy. Themes were actively developed through a reflexive process, rather than emerging passively from the data (Braun & Clarke, 2021b).

Data Collection and Instrument

Data were collected through semi-structured interviews, a widely employed qualitative method that facilitates the collection of open-ended responses and enables an in-depth exploration of participants' thoughts, feelings, and beliefs, including sensitive or personal topics (Artioli et al., 2019). This approach prioritizes the participant's perspective, focusing on understanding and interpreting the meanings they attribute to their experiences rather than explaining or predicting phenomena. Interviews were conducted within a relational context grounded in empathetic, non-judgmental listening, fostering a climate of mutual trust.

A flexible interview guide was prepared and used as a reference framework, dynamically adapted to emerging narrative content. The narrative interview was structured around three core themes: (1) AI and qualitative research; (2) potentials and limitations of AI use in qualitative research; and (3) future perspectives on AI application in qualitative research. Interviews began with an open, broad stimulus question: "What is being said about AI in your qualitative research environment?". This broad and open formulation was intentionally designed according to the principles of narrative interviewing, to give participants the freedom to construct and share their stories, perspectives, and experiences without being directed or constrained by narrowly defined questions. Notably, the term "Artificial Intelligence" was intentionally left undefined at the beginning of the interviews. This methodological choice was aligned with the narrative approach, aimed at exploring how participants spontaneously conceptualized AI within the context of their qualitative research experiences. By avoiding predefinitions or technical explanations, the interview process allowed for the emergence of participants' own meanings, associations, and assumptions related to AI.

The decision enabled us to capture the diversity of conceptualizations and applications that participants attributed to AI, treating this variability as an essential part of the phenomenon under investigation. We were aware that the open use of the term "AI" could generate ambiguity or misalignment in meaning between the interviewer and interviewee. To mitigate this, the interviewer used real-time reflective probing (e.g., "What do you mean by AI in this context?" or "Can you give me an example of the tool you are referring to?"), allowing for clarification of the participant's intended meaning without imposing predefined definitions. This approach supported a shared understanding while preserving the openness and exploratory nature of the interview.

Then, a natural, free-flowing conversation supported by open-ended and reflective prompts followed the open question. To balance structure with flexibility, the research team developed an interview guide identifying thematic areas for deeper exploration (Kallio et al., 2016). For transparency and reproducibility, the full interview guide is provided in Appendix 1. Probing questions such as "Can you elaborate?" and "What do you mean by that?" encouraged richer, more detailed responses. The interviewer maintained a neutral and empathetic stance, employing active listening techniques to ensure participant comfort. Key concepts and emerging themes were noted during the interviews. Sociodemographic information—including age, gender, educational level, professional role, years of experience in qualitative research, and AI usage—was also collected.

The interviews were conducted by a research nurse with extensive expertise in qualitative methods and interviewing techniques. The interviews were conducted between April and May 2025, with data analysis occurring concurrently to facilitate iterative coding and ensure continuous integration of findings. Three additional researchers observed the sessions, taking detailed field notes during and after each interview. Depending on participants' preferences, interviews were held either face to face or remotely via Microsoft Teams®.

With participants' consent, all sessions were audio-recorded and transcribed verbatim by the lead researcher shortly after each interview, following a rigorous and standardized protocol. Transcription included not only the spoken words but also relevant vocal elements such as pauses, intonation shifts, repetitions, hesitations (e.g., "uhm" and "you know"), and emotional expressions (e.g., laughter and sighs), in order to retain the depth and nuance of participants' narratives. To ensure consistency and fidelity to the original recordings, each transcript was cross-checked against the corresponding audio file by a second researcher. Discrepancies were resolved through collaborative review and discussion. To protect confidentiality, each transcript was anonymized through the replacement of all personal identifiers with pseudonyms or numerical codes. This process complied with the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) (European Parliament, 2016).

Field notes taken during the interviews were also used to contextualize the data and support interpretive accuracy. These notes, recorded by the three observing researchers during and after each session, focused on nonverbal behaviors, emotional expressions, and interactional cues that could enrich the understanding of participants' verbal accounts. Rather than being treated as a separate data source, these observational notes were transcribed alongside the interview transcripts and systematically integrated into the analytic process. In particular, they allowed the research team to identify and interpret moments of hesitation, emotional tone shifts, and alignment or dissonance between verbal and nonverbal communication. This integration of verbal and nonverbal data supported a more nuanced, context-sensitive, and embodied understanding of the narratives shared.

Consistent with Braun and Clarke's guidance on reflexive thematic analysis, sample size was determined by considering the depth and richness required to meaningfully address the study aims, rather than by pursuing data saturation (Braun & Clarke, 2021b). A total of 14 interviews provided a sufficiently information-rich dataset for developing well-supported themes. Written informed consent was obtained from all participants prior to each interview.

Data Analysis

Anonymized verbatim interview transcripts were analyzed using RTA, following Braun and Clarke's six-step framework (Braun & Clarke, 2006, 2019): (a) data familiarization; (b) systematic coding; (c) initial theme identification; (d) theme refinement and review; (e) finalization and naming of themes; and (f) writing up the results. Distinct from purely descriptive methods, RTA highlights the interpretative role of researchers and the dynamic relationship between language and experience. Codes were allowed to evolve throughout the analysis process (Braun & Clarke, 2006).

Data analysis began concurrently with the initial interviews, following the principles of an iterative and reflexive process. This approach allowed for the ongoing refinement of codes and themes, as preliminary insights from early interviews informed subsequent data collection and questioning. By analyzing data in parallel with the interviewing process, the research team was able to identify emerging patterns, adapt interview prompts where necessary, and deepen conceptual understanding throughout the study. This iterative dynamic enhanced the analytical depth and ensured a close alignment between participants' narratives and the evolving interpretive framework.

Specifically, two researchers (AS and CC) independently conducted a thorough, line-by-line manual coding of the transcripts, assigning concise labels to meaningful segments. Their coded datasets were then merged, and an initial thematic framework was developed. Discrepancies were resolved through reflective discussion and consensus. When necessary, two senior researchers (GA and FD) were consulted to ensure consistency, coherence, and rigor in theme development. The research team systematically reviewed and refined themes and subthemes to accurately represent overarching patterns in the participants' accounts. Representative quotations were selected to illustrate each theme. Consistent with RTA's interpretive epistemology, quantitative measures such as frequency counts or intercoder reliability were not reported (Braun & Clarke, 2021a). The entire analytic process was collaborative, emphasizing continuous reflection and shared interpretation of the data.

Rigor

To uphold methodological rigor and ensure trustworthiness, the study adhered to established criteria of credibility, transferability, and dependability (Crowe et al., 2015). Multiple strategies were implemented to enhance the accuracy and integrity of the data and its analysis. First, full verbatim transcription of all interviews was conducted to promote transparency and consistency throughout the analytic process (Crowe et al., 2015). Second, researchers engaged in reflexive practice, acknowledging their assumptions and using them as a resource for interpretation (Braun & Clarke, 2021a). Third, a second researcher with a background in nursing engaged with the dataset and offered a reflexive reading of the material. Rather than seeking consensus or objectivity, these additional interpretive insights were used to prompt deeper reflexive engagement and to consider alternative meanings in the data. Analytic discussions among the team focused on enhancing interpretive depth and coherence, rather than validating or adjudicating a single correct coding structure (Braun & Clarke, 2021a). Subsequently, a qualitative research expert engaged with the dataset and offered additional reflexive insights. Rather than validating or confirming the coding, these contributions were used to enrich interpretive depth and prompt consideration of alternative meanings. Team discussions focused on enhancing coherence and depth, not on adjudicating a single correct coding structure (Braun & Clarke, 2021a).

Additionally, emergent themes were subjected to collective discussion within the research team to establish a shared understanding and consensus on their meaning. In instances of disagreement, the team revisited pertinent data excerpts to refine interpretations. Divergent viewpoints regarding theme identification were resolved through collaborative dialogue, carefully reconsidering the data until consensus was achieved. Finally, member checking was conducted with a purposive subsample of three participants who had agreed to further contact. These individuals received a summary of preliminary themes via email and were invited to comment on the clarity, relevance, and resonance of the interpretations with their experiences. Their feedback affirmed the thematic structure, requiring no significant amendments, thereby strengthening the study's credibility (Doyle, 2007).

Ethical Considerations

Ethical approval for this study was obtained from the Regional Ethics Committee of Umbria (Protocol Letter No. 2027/2025, dated 16 April 2025). All participants provided informed consent prior to participation and were assured of confidentiality, anonymity, and the voluntary nature of their involvement. Data collection and storage complied with international ethical standards and the GDPR. Audio recordings and transcripts were anonymized and securely stored on encrypted institutional servers accessible only to authorized members of the research team. The study protocol was designed to minimize participant risk and ensure respect for participant autonomy throughout all research stages.

Results

Fourteen researchers participated in the study, evenly split between seven men and seven women. The participants had a mean age of 46 years (±11). Nearly all held a PhD, except for one participant currently pursuing doctoral studies. Among the interviewees, seven were university professors and researchers, including five academic scholars and two hospital-based researchers. Nine participants specialized in the socio-anthropological field (two anthropologists and seven sociologists), while five represented the medical and healthcare disciplines (one psychologist, two physicians, and two nurses). All participants were experienced researchers with over 10 years of research experience. They were affiliated with various universities across Central and Northern Italy. The 14 interviews had an average duration of 43 min, ranging from 23 to 93 min.

From the analysis of the 14 interviews, four main themes emerged, each described below along with their respective subthemes and illustrative quotations. To provide an overview of the qualitative findings, Table 1 summarizes the main themes, subthemes, and selected illustrative quotations that exemplify participants' perspectives.

Theme 1: Perspectives on AI and Qualitative Research

This theme explores how qualitative researchers perceive the intersection of AI and qualitative inquiry. The findings reveal a complex landscape marked by polarized and ambivalent views, which can be grouped into three main subthemes: (a) Prejudices and technophobia; (b) Shame and skill-related barriers; and (c) Openness and the need for control. Across these subthemes, the data show both consensus and significant diversity in attitudes toward AI.

Prejudices and Technophobia. In many qualitative research environments, AI is either not openly

Table 1. Overview of Themes, Subthemes, and Selected Quotations Developed From the Qualitative Analysis

Themes	Subtheme	Code	Cod	Representative data extracts
1. Perspectives on AI and qualitative research	Prejudices and technophobia	In anthropology, very little is said; there are no conferences … it is not used.	6.1	(Laughs) In my specific environment (Mhmm…), among other anthropology colleagues (Mhmm…), in this very specific field (Mhmm…), very little is said, there is very little discussion about this topic … there have been few opportunities for exchange.
		Regarding AI, there is skepticism among more established scholars, while younger individuals show a strong risk of infatuation.	12.1	Among more established scholars, there seems to be a certain skepticism, whereas among younger researchers, there appears to be a strong risk of infatuation. In fact, if you look at the research sociologists are doing on health, medicine, and various topics, new technologies in general—not just artificial intelligence but also telemedicine, telemonitoring, etc.—these are among the most popular themes, even at conferences and presentations.
		AI as a great resource—some see it as a danger, and this contrast is part of life	7.3	… so, there's a bit of everything: some are in favor, some are against, some see it as a great resource, others see it as a danger—and that's part of normal life, of politics.
		(…)	(…)	(…)
	Shame and skill-related barriers	There is still a fear of judgment; the use of AI is often hidden	8.31	Or, if it is used, it's not openly acknowledged. I don't know how to explain it, you know? It's kind of kept hidden, because I think there's still a fear of judgment—everything tends to be demonized. But then, in the darkness of our little rooms …
		We need to overcome the shame of declaring the use of AI. If it is used critically	4.32	The issue now, in my opinion, is the shame—or rather, the sense of embarrassment—that researchers feel when admitting they use artificial intelligence. Some are ashamed and don't say it openly. We all more or less use it when writing articles, but then when we submit to a journal, the journal asks how AI was used, and you have to declare it.
		I've been using AI in a self-taught way, without any particular expertise	5.19	To be honest, I've never really looked into it much—like how they're trained, what kind of tasks they can perform, or the quality of their output. I've just used it like that, without … well, without any particular expertise.
		(…)	(…)	(…)
	Openness and the need for control	For those with a more integrated vision, AI is seen as a valuable support.	2.1	And then there are those with a more integrated vision—those who imagine a full use and support from these new work tools.
		AI must be supported by critical thinking, which comes from being aware of the information that is being fed into it	12.17	It's about knowing what information to provide, what to leave out, and so on—but above all, it's about how to manage the outputs generated by the machine, knowing they're the result of the input we've given it. By modifying or altering that input, for example, we can see how the machine also changes the output. And this helps us understand the limitations of the machine itself.
		(…)	(…)	(…)

(continued)

Table 1. (continued)

Themes	Subtheme	Code	Cod	Representative data extracts
2. Anthropological and philosophical dimension	Distinction between humans and machines: Capacities and skills	If AI is used in a superficial way, without critical thinking, the result of the qualitative research will also be superficial—it won't spark reflection or open up a new perspective.	4.22	But if we use it in a superficial, purely functional way, without critical thinking, then what we'll get is a qualitative study that, when someone reads it, they'll just say, "Well, okay …"—you can tell. (Facial expressions reinforce this point.) My professor, when I was in Canada, used to say: when you read a qualitative study, you should say "Wow" or at least "Oh." It should spark reflection, open up new thoughts, offer a perspective you didn't have before.
		Qualitative research has an almost artisanal, even artistic quality. It offers a unique interpretative lens—something that cannot be replicated.	10.25	Qualitative research has that … that kind of artisanal quality—I don't want to say artistic (laughs), but it does have that dimension. Its added value lies in placing a specific reflection within a particular context, and in developing it in a certain way. There could have been a thousand other approaches, but the author's perspective was unique, and it offered an effective, insightful interpretation—one that leaves us with something that can't be replicated.
		(…)	(…)	(…)
	Human–machine relationship: AI as an "alter ego"	The researcher has the idea, and AI writes it well—even better than the person could	1.11	You read it and think, "Oh—I had that idea, but I would never have known how to write it so well!" It's expressed in a way that … it's amplified somehow. That's always been a bit of a challenge for me—not having full command of the language, not being able to express an idea as clearly as I'd like.
		AI can act as an additional voice—one that may pick up on aspects overlooked by human analysts.	7.9	When it comes to data analysis, you have another voice—an additional perspective at your disposal. And sometimes, not always, it reveals aspects that the analysts hadn't noticed until that moment. It's like having one more interlocutor, and it's one I consider to be valid.
		(…)	(…)	(…)
	Preserving human identity and the illusion of meaning	The researcher must be skilled not only in qualitative research but also in managing their relationship with AI	4.9	Qualitative research is only as good as the researcher—and that also applies to their relationship with artificial intelligence. It's not something automatic; it's an additional form of commitment, a process of tuning in and understanding AI.
		If properly trained, AI can create the illusion of meaning	2.3	AI could, in some way, create the illusion of certain meaning aggregates—it might reconstruct meaning in an interview from the interviewee's perspective. And that would be something new. I call it an "illusion of meaning" because, clearly, these are algorithmic inferences and combinations.
		(…)	(…)	(…)

(continued)

Table 1. (continued)

Themes	Subtheme	Code	Cod	Representative data extracts
3. Pragmatic dimension of AI usage	AI as support for technical tasks	The AI isn't able to produce a literature review, but the interviewee wonders whether they have the necessary skills to guide the AI in doing so	3.10	I don't know why, but sometimes when you go to check the sources he suggested—like, for example, if you ask him to do a literature review—he just can't do it. I don't know why, maybe it's me who doesn't know how to guide him properly, but he doesn't do it.
		AI was used for visual abstracts, making research more understandable to everyone	4.16	The advantage returns when it comes to dissemination, for example in modelling and even in visual modelling. I've tested it, for instance, in the context of some articles and presentations of studies we've done, where artificial intelligence helped me a lot in creating visual abstracts.
		To use ChatGPT: starting from a draft text, the AI translates it well.	1.12	Over the years, I've sometimes struggled to translate them into something understandable. In this regard, I think it helps a lot. In fact, I have to say that whenever I had the chance to use it, I did—just using ChatGPT in a very simple way: I'd give it a draft text and ask it to fix it, translate it into English, and write it well.
		(…)	(…)	(…)
	AI in qualitative research processes	To use AI to improve the methodology for constructing the article, providing very precise prompts and clear guidelines	9.8	I do a prompting job that's quite long and, I don't know, it takes some effort to explain things to ChatGPT. So I tell it: now think as if you were a qualitative researcher in palliative care. I give it all the journal links and ask it to tell me what, in its opinion, an article for that journal should look like—and it does, so I know it understood. At that point, I say: OK, I'd like to write this kind of article, which follows these writing guidelines. Let's start drafting a version.
		During exploration, the volume of data can be difficult to manage, and using AI to ask "what do you see that I don't?" can be very helpful.	13.13	Imagine that on the topic of migrant workers, a list comes out with 6000 newspaper articles. For "my migrant workers," maybe 2000 or 3000 sentences have been published. I asked the AI to identify three dominant narratives. It's similar to prompting, let's say … it can map and analyze what's being said. It's like asking: OK, what do you see that I don't?
		(…)	(…)	(…)
	Potentials and limitations	The main limitation is the user's level of training	2.18	What I see is the gap between us researchers and this tool, which has great potential but also significant limitations—and many of those limitations depend heavily on the user's level of training.
		Qualitative research still today requires fieldwork, which AI cannot do	5.36	Yes, then there's the point that qualitative research still often involves a … (uhm…) going down into the field (smiles), and artificial intelligence can't do that on its own, because it doesn't have a body (smiles).

(continued)

Table 1. (continued)

Themes	Subtheme	Code	Cod	Representative data extracts
4. Ethical and sustainability dimension	Ethical challenges	Ethically debated research requires an effort of époche, which is not made by those holding mainstream opinions—like AI.	9.26	There's, in my opinion, an interesting and serious debate around how, when conducting research on ethically controversial topics, you risk influencing the outcome with your own perspective. I believe there's a constant effort by those holding controversial opinions to avoid appearing controversial, whereas those with mainstream views make no effort at all to question their own position.
		There is no ethical code for researchers or university lecturers; it's a personally constructed work ethic.	10.16	As poor sociologists—or even more so as university lecturers—you don't have a code of ethics (smiles). You learn it by imitation, from what your mentors and the people you've worked with have passed on to you. So, it's all much more fragile, isn't it?
		The real challenge will be at the ethical level. AI shouldn't be demonized—its use must be correct, transparent, and intentional	14.11	Real challenges definitely exist. The ethical aspect will be one of them—it's something that needs regulation, just like the use of different software, right? It shouldn't be demonized; it's part of the technologies that will only continue to grow from now on.
		(…)	(…)	(…)
	Ecological sustainability challenges	We are not very focused on the ecological dimension of AI.	2.31	We're not very focused on the ecological dimension of artificial intelligence, because the real question will be: when AI becomes widespread, will we have the energy to sustain it? Is it truly sustainable in systemic terms? That's a key issue.
		The environmental impact is both direct—because servers are built in dry areas, then cooled with water, and the hot water is discharged into seas or rivers—and indirect, due to the increasing electricity consumption	13.20	Servers are built in dry areas with little water because humidity would damage the equipment. However, they require a huge amount of water to cool the servers, and then they release boiling water back into the sea or rivers. This process harms the environment, so there's a direct issue there. Also, there have been some recent studies—I listen to a few podcasts online—and it seems that energy consumption is becoming a major concern. I think a study came out recently, because I've heard it mentioned in several places, saying that by 2030, the AI economy will consume as much energy as Japan—basically, as much as an entire country.
		(…)	(…)	(…)

discussed—participants often reported that "people simply don't talk about it" (code 1.1), indicating a kind of collective avoidance—or is met with suspicion and skepticism. Expressions of technophobia and bias were evident, with some participants focusing on AI's flaws rather than its potential benefits: one noted that "they look for errors instead of possibilities" (code 3.2), highlighting a critical stance toward AI. Several participants took a strongly critical position, claiming that AI "undermines the researcher's creativity" (code 2.1), while others considered it a "threat to the essence of qualitative research" (code 4.2). Some even labeled AI as "an inherently ambiguous tool" (code 7.3), emphasizing that the ambiguity depends largely on how the technology is applied in practice. A minority adopted a firm, uncompromising stance: for example, one participant argued, "AI doesn't help me conduct research (…) because of the specific nature of this [anthropological] approach" (code 6.11).

Seven of the fourteen interviewees acknowledged prejudices against AI in their professional circles, suggesting that skepticism is present among a substantial proportion of the qualitative research community.

Shame and Skill-Related Barriers. Analysis of nonverbal cues and field notes suggested a certain discomfort or reluctance among participants when discussing their use of AI. As noted in a field memo, "Several participants initially claimed they were only considering using AI, but during the interview, clarified how and where they were already employing it" (field note 1), revealing a kind of hesitation to openly acknowledge AI use. Some participants admitted to a persistent "fear of being judged" (code 8.31), which often led to concealing their use of AI. Others emphasized the importance of "overcoming the shame of disclosing AI use" (code 4.32), especially among those striving to adopt AI tools critically, engaging in discussion and reflection rather than passive acceptance. Interestingly, a few participants realized during the interview that they were already using AI-based tools unintentionally, as exemplified by one who reflected, "Thinking about it more carefully … I do use NVivo, which has transitioned to Lumivero, and yes, it's still a software that uses AI" (code 10.4). In fact, 13 out of 14 researchers admitted—albeit sometimes with reluctance—that they use AI in some form within their research workflows.

Even among those more receptive to AI, its adoption was often linked to their level of technical proficiency. Most participants reported relying on general-purpose tools like "ChatGPT" (code 7.24), while expressing a desire for "more specialized and refined tool tailored to the field" (code 11.15). Many acknowledged not knowing "whether they are fully aware of AI's capabilities" (code 1.24) and stated they had started using it "as self-learners, without any formal training" (code 5.20). Overall, there was a shared awareness of "the limited AI literacy among qualitative researchers" (code 8.24), along with a collective acknowledgment of the need to promote more informed, reflective, and ethical use of these technologies. Despite differing perceptions, there was a notable consensus among interviewees about the necessity to improve AI-related competencies for qualitative research.

Openness and the Need for Control. Some participants adopted a more open and pragmatic attitude, describing AI as a "supportive tool for researchers" (code 2.1), and advocating for "greater openness" (code 5.2) regarding its use in qualitative inquiry. One participant, drawing on a social constructivist perspective, argued that AI should be "taken seriously and actively engaged with" (code 4.2). In an increasingly AI-permeated world, researchers acknowledged that "we cannot ignore its presence" (code 8.22); instead, it must be understood and used appropriately. For many, AI represents "an emerging and still unexplored field" within the qualitative research community (code 11.1). Those more receptive to AI spoke of its "captivating potential" (code 3.30) and described a sense of "wonder" (code 10.15) at what it could achieve. Although there is currently "no established framework for AI use in qualitative research" (code 4.33), many viewed it as "a valuable resource capable of facilitating the research process" (code 9.22). Nonetheless, participants consistently emphasized the importance of "safeguarding data security and integrity" (code 11.12) and maintaining "a critical human layer of oversight" (code 12.17) to ensure responsible and contextually appropriate use. An open vision of AI use gained consensus among nearly all interviewees, yet several stressed the crucial need to preserve human control and ethical vigilance.

Theme 2: Anthropological and Philosophical Dimension

Before delving into more pragmatic considerations, the interviewees situated AI within a broader context—focusing particularly on its relationship with humans and their inherent qualities. This theme reveals a rich and nuanced understanding among participants, highlighting both strong consensus and some divergence of views. It is structured around three subthemes: (a) the distinction between humans and machines: Capacities and Skills; (b) Human–Machine Relationship: AI as an "Alter Ego"; and (c) the preservation of human identity.

Distinction Between Humans and Machines: Capacities and Skills. It is important to clarify that all reflections pertain to the current state of AI and existing knowledge. None of the participants speculated about future developments, citing the absence of concrete evidence to support such forecasts. Within this framework, participants widely agreed that humans possess certain "higher-order" cognitive capacities that machines currently lack, while regarding AI as possessing "skills" that can be acquired through appropriate human training. For example, one participant emphasized, "Critical thinking and reflexivity are distinctly human capacities that AI cannot replicate" (code 3.27); without them, "AI risks producing superficial results that fail to stimulate true reflection or open new perspectives" (code 4.22). Similarly, the "interpretative sensitivity of the researcher" (code 1.47), the ability to draw connections and infer latent meanings, as well as "intuitive intelligence and creativity" (code 11.24) were unanimously considered irreplaceable qualities, deeply rooted in "personal experiential knowledge" (code 6.8).

Additionally, uniquely human abilities such as idea generation (code 4.18), offering novel insights, and adopting a "cross-disciplinary perspective with the courage to forge original links" (5.16) were highlighted—all rooted in humans' capacity for "multisensory language" (code 10.25). A more cautious note was sounded regarding the potential for "erosion of consciousness and the processes of internalization and emotional intimacy" (code 12.25), which participants linked to a flattening of meaning through oversimplification. This concern was shared by the majority, suggesting a strong consensus around the importance of preserving the depth of human cognition.

Human–Machine Relationship: AI as an "Alter Ego". Participants described the researcher–AI relationship as characterized by two main, sometimes complementary, dynamics. On one hand, AI serves as a supportive instrument, with the researcher maintaining control over the research process. In this light, "the researcher conceives the idea, and AI articulates it effectively" (code 1.11)—sometimes even better than the researcher themselves. The vast majority (for 13 out of 14 participants) agreed that "the researcher remains the primary instrument of qualitative research, co-constructing knowledge with participants, while technology serves as a support tool" (code 4.4). AI was especially valued when handling "large datasets where distinguishing subtle meanings is challenging" (code 13.10), with researchers requesting AI's input—for example, "tell me what you see that I might have missed" (code 11.13), while ultimately retaining full responsibility and final judgment.

Conversely, for 9 out of 14 participants, AI was also perceived as "an excellent interlocutor […] an alternative voice". (code 7.9) capable of identifying overlooked aspects and contributing to a shared, comprehensive analysis. It was metaphorically likened to "a soulless research assistant" who can even be "argued with" without causing offense. Of particular interest was the ability to engage in dialogue with AI, described as "a synthesis of many voices" (code 3.27), a "collective colleague" (code 12.5) enhancing the "researcher's self-reflexivity" (code 4.20) and facilitating "the co-construction of meaning" (code 9.10). Despite acknowledging that AI remains "a collaborator whose data processing methods are somewhat opaque" (code 11.20), participants believed that with training, AI could be guided from novice to expert-level use within qualitative research, suggesting a hopeful, evolving partnership.

Preserving Human Identity and the Illusion of Meaning. Participants acknowledged significant risks associated with AI use, foremost among them the potential "erosion of the researcher's identity" (code 4.9). Several noted that the qualitative researcher's role could become "impoverished and flattened" (code 8.27), with diminished control over the research process. One participant shared a personal reflection: "I sometimes feel displaced, like I engage less intellectually and contribute less personally when relying heavily on AI" (code 1.29). There was broad recognition of the risk of "naïve reliance" on AI (code 2.19), even given its considerable capabilities. A generational gap emerged clearly: younger researchers tended to embrace AI more readily, while senior researchers expressed concern about their ability "to guide and educate younger colleagues in developing critical judgment regarding AI" (code 11.13), which they deemed essential for its responsible use.

AI was seen as enabling the achievement of "goals that are not inherently scientific" (code 4.9), "driven instead by organizational demands emphasizing speed, output, and publication over knowledge creation and process quality" (code 12.21). Even when properly trained, AI may produce "aggregated meanings" (code 2.3) derived from textual analysis, potentially reconstructing the interview's meaning from the interviewee's perspective. However, this was viewed as an "illusion of meaning" (code 2.4). One participant emphasized this with notable nonverbal and paraverbal cues: "The illusion of sense produced by AI outputs is striking—expressed through a firm tone of voice and intense eye contact"—highlighting the depth of concern regarding the authenticity of AI-generated interpretations (field note 5). Despite proficiency with AI tools, participants emphasized that human oversight remains indispensable to ensure validity and accuracy, underscoring a shared conviction about the irreplaceable role of human judgment in qualitative research.

Theme 3: Pragmatic Dimension of AI Usage

Theme 3 examines the pragmatic aspect of AI integration in qualitative research focusing on three core areas: AI as a technical support tool, its involvement in various research processes, and the perceived strengths and limitations of its application.

AI as Support for Technical Tasks. Participants widely acknowledged AI as a valuable tool for well-defined technical tasks in qualitative research. In particular, all participants recognized the improvement in the accuracy and efficiency of "transcribing audio recordings" (code 2.6), which they identified as one of the most straightforward and time-saving applications of AI. However, literature review tasks generated more mixed views. Some researchers "admit to lacking the necessary skills" (code 3.10) to perform literature reviews properly using AI, while others who have experience with it consider such reviews "inaccurate and unreliable in validating sources" (code 8.7), especially due to the risk of fabricated or biased citations. AI is also recognized as helpful for "summarizing content" (code 2.4) and generating "abstracts and visual models" (code 4.16), though participants stressed that human oversight remains essential to ensure accuracy and coherence.

The most significant consensus emerged around the use of AI to support writing in scientific English. Thirteen out of fourteen participants reported relying on AI tools for "translating from Italian to English" (code 1.12) and for AI-assisted "scientific English writing" (code 13.15). This widespread appreciation reflects the concrete benefits of AI in overcoming language barriers and improving productivity. Overall, AI's role in technical tasks was characterized by a high level of consensus among participants, who viewed these applications as practical, low-risk, and time-efficient.

AI in Qualitative Research Processes. When addressing more complex and interpretative phases of qualitative research, such as study design, data collection, and data analysis, participants expressed a broader diversity of opinions. Two interviewees stated they have "never used AI to design a study" (code 10.5) or *to* "collect data" (code 1.19). Conversely, some participants showed trust in AI's growing proficiency with "qualitative research methodology" (code 5.24) and expressed satisfaction with AI's role in "structuring manuscripts by providing tailored prompts aligned with guidelines" (code 9.8). The use of AI in data analysis elicited the most polarized views. Several participants said they have "never used AI for interview analysis" (code 9.9), describing it as "a black box that obscures the rationale behind selecting one excerpt over another" (code 9.9), making it difficult to verify or justify analytical choices. Others raised ethical and methodological concerns, warning that "AI can produce results based on weak premises (…) essentially simulating a false narrative" (code 10.14). On the other hand, some participants reported using AI for "discourse analysis on large volumes of data" (code 13.11), highlighting its potential for handling big data, although they emphasized that results remain ambiguous and require substantial interpretation by the researcher. A few participants noted they had "never compared manual thematic analysis with AI-assisted analysis" (code 2.8), thus lacking an evaluation of the differences or similarities between the two approaches. In sum, while technical support tasks elicited broad agreement, AI's integration into core qualitative research processes revealed divergent experiences and uncertainties, especially regarding analytical transparency and trustworthiness.

Potentials and Limitations. Participants expressed more caution than enthusiasm when reflecting on the potentials of AI in qualitative research. While a few interviewees foresaw the possibility that AI could "facilitate dialogue between different methodologies and disciplines" (code 5.44), others openly admitted they were "unable to envision future applications" (code 3.30), suggesting a lack of clear foresight or strategic integration. There was strong agreement among participants in identifying "insufficient training of users" (code 2.18), as the predominant limitation. Several noted that AI tools are often used in naïve or uncritical ways, leading to superficial or inappropriate outcomes. While "remote webinars are available, but structured, advanced training programs remain scarce" (code 14.12), leaving researchers to rely on trial-and-error or peer support. Another major concern concerned AI's inability to replicate distinctively human cognitive functions. One researcher emphasized, "AI is not human (…) it is not me" (code 6.20), highlighting that AI lacks "meta-cognition, consciousness" (code 12.12) and the "ability to generate original ideas" (code 4.18)—all distinctively human traits.

A widely shared view among participants was that "AI has no role in ethnographic research" (code 4.26), given that such work "still requires direct field immersion, which AI cannot perform" (code 5.36). AI can also "instill apprehension" (code 3.24) due to the lack of transparency and control over its processes. Despite these concerns, some interviewees acknowledged the rapid evolution of AI and anticipated major shifts in the near future. As one participant put it, "in as little as a year, the landscape may be entirely transformed" (code 9.12), reflecting a cautious openness to future developments, even among the skeptics. In conclusion, Theme 3 reveals a nuanced and often ambivalent view of AI's practical applications. While technical tasks appear to benefit from AI integration and enjoy wide support, its role in interpretive processes and methodological design remains contested. The findings underscore the need for better training, critical awareness, and methodological reflection to navigate the promises and pitfalls of AI in qualitative research.

Theme 4: Ethical and Sustainability Dimension

The fourth theme explores the complex web of ethical and ecological concerns raised by participants in relation to the integration of AI in qualitative research. Far from being marginal, these issues emerged as central, underpinning much of the discomfort, resistance, and critical engagement expressed toward the evolving role of intelligent systems. The theme is articulated through two interrelated subthemes: (a) Ethical challenges and (b) Ecological sustainability challenges.

Ethical Challenges. Across all interviews, ethical concerns were explicitly or implicitly mentioned, reflecting a shared apprehension that the rapid deployment of AI technologies is outpacing ethical scrutiny. Participants emphasized the concentration of power among a few actors—particularly those who design and train AI systems—as a significant threat to research integrity and social justice. One participant noted that AI fundamentally relies on a “dominant form of knowledge” (code 3.37), drawing “information and content from prevailing epistemologies” (code 9.27), which are predominantly Western. This reliance risks perpetuating cultural biases by marginalizing “voices, perspectives, and minority viewpoints from subcultures or underrepresented groups” (code 5.26). Additionally, the use of personal data raises critical questions about “how the input data will be utilized” (code 12.10) and how the economic value generated from these data—now no longer private—will be shared. Participants questioned, “Who is actually using this data? (…) Are some profiting from your data? (…) And is this wealth being fairly redistributed?” (code 3.39).

Participants lamented the absence of a universally accepted ethical code. In this vacuum, decisions are often left to the researcher’s own “personal moral reflection” (code 10.16), which may be well-intentioned but ultimately insufficient. There was widespread consensus on the need for robust regulatory structures and transparent governance mechanisms to ensure the “ethical, proper, declared, and intentional use” (code 14.11), of AI technologies. One participant emphasized the urgency of a “thoughtful consideration of governance frameworks” (code 13.22), warning that ethical decisions should not be left to individual discretion alone.

For some participants, these concerns pointed to a broader anthropological shift. The rise of AI, they argued, reflects and accelerates a transition from a post-industrial society to a digital one. As one interviewee put it, “We are witnessing a transition from a post-industrial society to a digital one, and with it, an AI-mediated redefinition of what it means to be human” (code 12.13). In this context, AI’s role in mediating knowledge production, decision-making, and human relationships raises fundamental questions about autonomy, emotional labor, and interpersonal connection.

Ecological Sustainability Challenges. Although discussed less frequently, the ecological implications of AI were raised by a subset of participants as an urgent but underexplored concern. These reflections pointed to the hidden environmental costs of AI systems—particularly their intensive energy demands—and the lack of broader awareness in the academic community. A recurring critique targeted what one participant termed “technological anthropocentrism” (code 2.30), whereby the drive for computational power eclipses environmental responsibility. AI systems, especially large-scale models, require vast computational resources. One participant remarked, “AI is projected to consume as much energy as the entire country of Japan” (code 13.20), a statistic that starkly illustrates the scale of its environmental impact. Another participant observed, “One realizes that server usage has significant environmental repercussions” (code 3.38), highlighting how the environmental footprint of AI is often overlooked.

This awareness was echoed in a field note: “Ecological issues are emphasized with particular intensity by participants, especially because they recognize how little attention this topic still receives” (field note 10). While only a few interviewees had fully integrated ecological thinking into their assessment of AI, those who had were unequivocal. As one asked provocatively, “Can qualitative research afford to overlook the ecological implications of artificial intelligence?” (code 2.33). Another elaborated, “We don’t often think about the carbon footprint of running servers 24/7. But it matters. It has to matter—especially in academia, where we’re supposed to be leading by example” (code 3.38). These ecological concerns were not only technical or operational but deeply existential. They gave rise to broader anthropological reflections about the kind of future AI is shaping. As one participant asked, “What kind of future are we building with these technologies? Who is it for? And what are we willing to sacrifice in the process?” (code 2.33). Sustainability, in this framing, extends beyond energy consumption to encompass cultural, ethical, and intergenerational responsibility.

Discussion

This study explored, for the first time, the views and perceptions of a community of qualitative researchers regarding the use of AI in qualitative research. Although the literature on this topic is rapidly growing, our study provides a unique contribution by focusing on the nuanced perspectives of expert researchers operating in Italian academic and healthcare environments. This context remains underexplored. The findings revealed a contrast between the widespread, often uncontrolled presence of AI in society and the more reserved, sometimes undeclared, use of AI within qualitative research. Despite its significant potential, AI is not fully utilized in this field, partly due to limited technical expertise and a rather superficial or "naïve" approach to its application. AI is commonly employed for specific tasks such as transcription, translation, and document summarization. However, researchers maintain control over more complex tasks, especially data analysis and interpretive phases. A key concern raised is the potential for an "illusion of meaning," even when using advanced AI tools. This concern touches on deeper anthropological and ethical questions regarding human dominance over machines and the risks of over-reliance.

There is a growing body of literature on the use of AI in qualitative research. Some studies have focused on AI-conducted interviews, showing that AI can generate rich data at lower costs (Chopra & Haaland, 2023). Others have explored AI-assisted thematic analysis, particularly in health research, highlighting its benefits for data organization and interpretation while noting concerns about reflexivity and privacy (Hitch, 2024). Ethical challenges have also been discussed, with calls for evolving guidelines to protect research integrity (Davison et al., 2024). Recent studies on human–AI collaboration emphasize both potential benefits, such as efficiency, and risks related to trust, reliability, and contextual understanding (Yan et al., 2024). Building on this literature, our study offers a different perspective. Rather than testing AI tools directly, we explore the views of expert qualitative researchers working in Italian academic and healthcare contexts. This reflexive approach allows us to capture both common concerns and culturally or disciplinarily specific perspectives. In doing so, our findings complement the global debate by stressing the need to balance the integration of AI with the preservation of human interpretative agency.

Several studies have examined AI use in healthcare and its public perception (Gundlack et al., 2025; Hassan et al., 2024; Wu et al., 2023). Similarly, in qualitative research, AI has been applied to support scientific writing (Huang & Tan, 2023), assist non-native English speakers (Meyer et al., 2023), and summarize documents. Consistent with our findings, these applications are specific and limited. One evident result is the hesitation among researchers to openly acknowledge using AI. This lack of transparency may lead to under-reporting its use or result in inadequate documentation—an issue made more relevant as many journals now require explicit AI usage statements. This situation raises concerns about the extent of undisclosed AI-generated content in scientific publications. Participants also expressed skepticism about AI's reliability in literature reviews and data analysis, recognizing that AI tools still lack precision. Most had not conducted formal comparisons between human and machine-driven analysis—unlike recent studies that highlight risks for novice researchers, low coding reliability, and the need for human oversight (Christou, 2024; Friedman et al., 2024; Kon et al., 2025; Prescott et al., 2024).

AI is generally seen as a collaborator or assistant (Turobov et al., 2024), and while its contributions across all research stages are acknowledged, doubts remain about performance adequacy (Schroeder et al., 2025). The limited use is partly attributed to researchers' low AI literacy and the need for specific training (Naeem et al., 2025). Beyond technical proficiency, there is a growing consensus on the necessity of comprehensive professional development programs that integrate critical reflections on AI's role in qualitative research. As emphasized by Chopra and Haaland (2023) and Dahal (2024), such training should not only focus on practical skills but also on understanding the opportunities and challenges that generative AI presents, including potential methodological shifts and ethical dilemmas. Mollick (2024) highlights the concept of "co-intelligence," underscoring the importance of human–AI collaboration, where researchers develop symbiotic relationships with AI tools rather than viewing them as mere instruments (Mollick, 2024). Furthermore, Davison and collogues (2024) stress the ethical imperatives in AI integration, advocating for educational frameworks that foster responsible AI use respecting data integrity and participant privacy (Davison et al., 2024). Embedding these perspectives into qualitative research education—at both graduate and continuing professional development levels—can empower researchers to harness AI capabilities for coding, analysis, and data management, while maintaining reflexivity, creativity, and critical oversight (Nguyen-Trung, 2025; Paulus & Marone, 2025). Such holistic educational approaches help mitigate risks of over-reliance on AI and support the preservation of the nuanced, interpretative essence of qualitative inquiry. This reflects a broader, international need for structured professional development pathways that support qualitative researchers in acquiring both technical competence and critical awareness regarding AI tools and their implications. However, a key consideration is that increasing AI proficiency may risk replacing the deep learning and reflective thinking intrinsic to qualitative research.

Experts in digital society have started to rigorously compare human and AI-driven analysis (De Paoli, 2024a, 2024b). It remains uncertain whether a single individual can develop strong expertise in both qualitative research and AI simultaneously. Some studies advocate for interprofessional teams that combine technical and research expertise (Chen et al., 2025; Pattyn, 2024). This suggests that rather than qualitative researchers needing to master AI entirely, support from AI experts could be valuable.

Interviewed researchers emphasized that while AI can support research, certain core elements—such as reflexivity, creativity, intuition, emotional awareness, and contextual sensitivity—are inherently human. They highlighted the importance of immersion in context and the development of sensitivity and tacit knowledge over time. While acknowledging AI's remarkable capabilities and potential, participants remained cautious about the "illusion of meaning" it may generate (Nyaaba et al., 2025). In our context, this "illusion" refers to a subtle and often barely perceptible risk: the possibility that researchers may attribute genuine interpretive value to outputs that, while coherent on the surface, could in fact be misleading. Participants suggested that vigilance is required to avoid assuming that machine-led analysis can autonomously produce valid insights without the continuous involvement of the human researcher. They expressed concerns about researchers' ability to fully understand and verify AI-generated processes. Even when AI produces seemingly meaningful insights, there is no absolute guarantee that these are not misleading (Gibson & Beattie, 2024). While some literature highlights idea generation as one of generative AI's strengths (Mollick, 2024), our interviewees—though sometimes surprised by AI's creative potential—consistently stressed that the researcher's interpretive role remains indispensable, a view also echoed in existing scholarship. Interestingly, they refrained from speculating on the future evolution of AI, citing the unpredictability of its rapid development. This suggests that longitudinal follow-up studies, for example, after one year, could be valuable for assessing changes in perceptions and practices over time.

Although AI can drastically reduce the time needed to process large datasets, concerns persist about the validity of its semantic groupings. Current studies call for continued experimentation, with rigorous evaluations ideally conducted by multidisciplinary teams (Turobov et al., 2024). The literature highlights ethical challenges in using AI for qualitative research, particularly risks to its philosophical and epistemological foundations (Chatzichristos, 2025; Friedman et al., 2024; Marshall & Naff, 2024). Scholars call for cautious AI use, respecting data integrity while acknowledging the evolving digital landscape of qualitative methods (Ntsobi et al., 2024). There is also an urgent need for clear guidelines and rigorous validation, as current empirical testing is limited (Schroeder et al., 2025; Turobov et al., 2024). Our interviewees echo these concerns but broaden the discussion to systemic and political issues, including data ownership, governance, profit motives, equitable access, and the influence of Western versus Eastern AI platforms. They also highlight often-overlooked environmental and economic sustainability challenges, questioning whether AI development will prioritize effectiveness or be constrained by emerging sustainability issues.

Building upon the themes identified in this study, it is clear that a balanced integration of AI into qualitative research is essential—one that preserves the uniquely human elements of reflexivity, creativity, and contextual sensitivity. To achieve this, both researchers and institutions should prioritize fostering critical AI literacy and ethical awareness through targeted professional development initiatives. These programs would equip qualitative researchers with the technical competencies and critical mindset necessary to responsibly navigate AI tools, ensuring their use enhances rather than diminishes the rigor and depth of qualitative inquiry. The findings also highlight a concerning underreporting of AI usage in qualitative research, which underscores the urgent need for transparent guidelines and institutional policies that encourage explicit disclosure and ethical governance of AI applications. Such transparency is fundamental for maintaining the integrity of research and sustaining public trust.

Looking ahead, future research should expand beyond the prevalent focus on human–AI comparisons. There is significant scope to explore the broader epistemological, methodological, and practical implications of AI integration. For instance, forming interprofessional teams that combine AI experts with qualitative researchers may harness complementary skills and foster more effective, ethically grounded research collaborations. Finally, participants' concerns regarding the ethical, political, economic, and sustainability dimensions of AI use remind us that AI integration must be accompanied by ongoing critical discourse and collaborative efforts among researchers, policymakers, and technology developers. Such collaboration is vital to ensure that AI advances promote equity, environmental sustainability, and respect for data sovereignty, thereby supporting a responsible and context-sensitive evolution of qualitative research.

Limitations. This study presents several limitations. The sample, composed primarily of qualitative researchers from specific academic and geographic contexts, may not fully capture the diversity of views across disciplines, institutions, or regions, limiting the transferability of findings. Furthermore, considering the rapid evolution of AI technologies, participants' perceptions and concerns may quickly become outdated, potentially limiting the long-term relevance of the insights obtained. The qualitative approach, while rich in depth, relies on subjective interpretations, which, despite rigorous methodological safeguards, may introduce researcher bias. Furthermore, the focus on ethical, political, and sustainability issues may have led to underexploration of technical challenges or practical barriers to AI integration in qualitative research.

Our findings are based on participants' subjective perceptions and self-reported experiences within their research environments. While these accounts provide valuable insights into how qualitative researchers view AI integration, they do not represent direct observations of workplace practices. This distinction is important, as perceptions may differ from actual behaviors and processes. Consequently, our assertions are limited to understanding researchers' views rather than empirical descriptions of AI usage in qualitative research settings. Future research incorporating observational methods or mixed-methods designs could provide a more comprehensive picture of AI integration in practice.

Another limitation concerns the lack of a shared, explicit definition of "Artificial Intelligence" provided during the interviews. While this was a deliberate methodological choice intended to elicit participants' own conceptualizations, it may have resulted in interpretive variability and a lack of clarity about whether participants and researchers were referring to the same technologies, tools, or applications. This ambiguity, although methodologically meaningful in exploring divergent understandings—given the diversity of AI tools referenced by participants such as ChatGPT and NVivo/Lumivero—may also have limited the comparability of responses. Future studies could address these gaps by incorporating a wider range of perspectives, more explicit operational definitions of AI, and methodological approaches aimed at clarifying the types of tools discussed.

Interestingly, none of the participants mentioned the use of AI translation tools, despite their increasing prevalence in academic and research contexts. This absence may be due to the specific linguistic or institutional contexts of our sample, or because translation was not a primary concern in their qualitative research activities. This gap highlights an area for further investigation, as AI translation facilities may play a significant role in supporting researchers, particularly those working in multilingual settings.

The sample was selected to provide sufficient depth and richness to meaningfully address the research aims. However, the diversity of the sample was limited in terms of geographic distribution, academic disciplines, and institutional contexts. This limitation may affect the transferability of the findings to broader qualitative research communities. We recognize that theoretical saturation does not guarantee representativeness or full diversity, and future studies should aim to include a wider range of perspectives to enhance generalizability. Future studies could address these gaps by incorporating a wider range of perspectives and methodological approaches.

Implications for Practice and Further Research. This study contributes by promoting a balanced understanding of AI's role in qualitative research—encouraging a critical yet open approach rather than polarized rejection or blind acceptance. It highlights the need for qualitative researchers to be more aware of AI's potential benefits and risks, alongside transparent reporting and the establishment of ethical guidelines to govern its use. Beyond the need for technical proficiency, universities and research organizations should promote training initiatives aimed at fostering critical and conscious engagement with AI tools. Moreover, clear and widely shared institutional guidelines on the ethical use of AI are essential. While some universities—including several in Italy—have already implemented such frameworks, these efforts should be further developed and regularly updated to keep pace with the rapid evolution of AI technologies and their potential impact on qualitative inquiry. Given the variety of AI tools and applications referenced by participants, future practice should also emphasize clear communication and explicit definitions regarding AI technologies employed in research to ensure shared understanding and comparability.

Further research is needed to rigorously compare outcomes from traditional, human-led qualitative methods with those generated or supported by AI. Beyond methodological concerns, such research should explore the epistemological and paradigmatic impacts on qualitative inquiry. Additionally, it would be worthwhile to involve scholars in philosophy and philosophy of science in future investigations. Their contributions could help unpack the deeper epistemological and paradigmatic implications of integrating AI into qualitative inquiry, thereby enriching the theoretical foundations and guiding responsible, context-sensitive applications. Moreover, future research should aim to clarify the terminology surrounding AI use. In particular, explicitly asking participants to define what they mean by "Artificial Intelligence" could help ensure a shared understanding and improve the comparability of findings. Our research program already includes a planned one-year follow-up study involving the same qualitative researchers, aimed at exploring whether and how their perceptions, practices, and conceptualizations of AI have changed over time. This next phase will integrate a more focused exploration of definitions and terminological clarity, in line with the recommendation provided.

Future research should extend beyond comparative analyses of human versus AI-supported coding to explore deeper questions about the evolving nature of qualitative inquiry in the AI era. This includes examining epistemological transformations, methodological innovations enabled or challenged by AI, ethical implications of AI integration, and how researcher identities and practices may shift. Such work would enrich our understanding of AI's role in shaping the future landscape of qualitative research. Finally, it is essential to address the ethical, equity, political, economic, and sustainability challenges that AI's widespread adoption may entail.

Conclusions

The findings of this study contribute to the ongoing and timely debate on the use of AI in qualitative research. Researchers within the qualitative scientific community generally acknowledge and accept the evolving nature of technology, including the integration of AI. Faced with instances of "naïve use" of AI capabilities—often stemming from limited expertise—researchers advocate for the increased involvement of multidisciplinary teams, including computer scientists and engineers, to better tailor AI prompts to the specific needs of qualitative inquiry.

A point of consensus among participants is the enduring centrality and supremacy of the human researcher in qualitative research. They recognize that certain inherently human capacities—complex, nuanced, and deeply sensitive—will remain uniquely human even as AI systems advance in sophistication. In this respect, researchers also recommend maintaining a degree of "benefit of the doubt" to avoid what some have termed the "illusion of meaning." Advanced expertise, vigilant oversight of AI-generated outputs, critical evaluative skills, and the unique potential of human intelligence are qualities unlikely to be fully replicated by algorithms.

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Ethical Considerations

This study was approved by the Regional Ethics Committee of Umbria (Protocol Letter No. 2027/2025, dated 16 April 2025). All participants provided informed electronic consent prior to enrollment, after receiving comprehensive study information via Google Forms. Consent included permission for video recording. Participation was voluntary, and participants were informed of their right to withdraw at any time without consequences. Strict measures were taken to protect participants' anonymity and privacy in compliance with the General Data Protection Regulation (EU Regulation 2016/679). Unique numerical codes were assigned to both participants and interviewers to safeguard identities. Audio recordings and transcripts were anonymized and securely stored on encrypted, password-protected institutional servers accessible only to authorized research team members. Backup data were maintained on encrypted external drives stored in locked cabinets at the university. Data access was logged and monitored continuously to ensure confidentiality. The study protocol was designed to minimize risks and ensure participant safety throughout all research stages.

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Appendix 1: Narrative Semi-Structured Interview Guide for Professionals

Instructions for the Interviewer

Introduce yourself and thank the participant for their involvement. Explain the study objective:

This study aims to explore the perceptions and perspectives of expert qualitative researchers regarding Artificial Intelligence (AI) and its application in qualitative research projects.

Before starting the online interview, provide information about the study, assure confidentiality, request consent, and have the participant sign the appropriate forms.

If an observer is present, their role is to observe and take notes ("memos") on the participant's nonverbal behavior.

The interview focuses on understanding qualitative researchers' opinions on the potential use of AI in qualitative research and is structured into three sections exploring the following key areas:

Thematic Areas

(1) AI and qualitative research
(2) Potentials and limitations of AI use in qualitative research
(3) Future perspectives on AI application in qualitative research

For each area, example questions are provided. While conducting the interview, the interviewer should refer to these questions. However, to ensure a natural flow and a trusting, non-judgmental atmosphere, questions may be asked in a different order than presented and adapted based on the participant's verbal and nonverbal cues. Questions can be varied and reformulated as the conversation evolves. At the end of the interview, verify that all topics have been covered.

Introduction to the Interview

At this stage, aim to make the participant comfortable by thanking them for accepting the invitation and offering to clarify any doubts.

Thank you for being here.

Briefly explain the interview structure.

Opening Question

(1) What is being said about AI in your qualitative research work environment?

Theme 1: AI and Qualitative Research

(1) What is your general opinion on the use of AI in qualitative research?
(2) How do you think AI might influence the process of collecting and analyzing qualitative data?
(3) Could you provide an example?

(4) Can you share any experiences, yours or your colleagues', with AI in qualitative research?

Theme 2: Potentials and Limitations of AI in Qualitative Research

(1) What do you consider the main potentials of AI in supporting qualitative research?
(2) Are there any challenges or limitations you have observed or anticipate in the use of AI in this context?
(3) Do you think AI could reduce or amplify bias in qualitative research?

Theme 3: Future Perspectives on AI in Qualitative Research

(1) How do you see the evolution of AI use in qualitative research over the coming years?
(2) How do you think AI might change the role of the qualitative researcher in the future? Could you provide an example?
(3) Is there anything important you believe should be further considered or explored regarding AI use in qualitative research?

Concluding Questions

(1) Do you have any additional reflections or comments you would like to share on this topic?
(2) Is there anything we have not discussed that you consider relevant to add?

Closure

Thank the participant for their time and contribution.

Provide information about the next steps of the study and availability for any future contact.